all the philosophers that he reads, Heidegger captivates him the most, especially due to his idea that the notion of death is central to human thinking. For most of us, death is so overbearing that we shy away from discussing it, so it's a difficult moral position for Lorenzo (or anybody else) to accept."

Of course, the Chatterjee of wickedly funny fare like *The Mammaries of the Welfare State* (2000) resurfaces every now and then. Here, humour is used in short, sharp bursts, an explosion of imagery standing out amidst contemplative, inward-looking passages. Here's Chatterjee's description of a statue of Time at the Praglia monastery, where Lorenzo studies with the monks. "Time has the physique of a young man who spends twenty hours a day at the gym with a personal trainer. He is in the nude except for a sort of double bedcover that covers his head and left shoulder and falls in wasteful folds behind him only to flip around his right knee and rise up—tantalisingly—to just about cover his loins. (...) Time needs, so the visitor concludes, all that muscle and that eight-pack stomach because he has for centuries had to carry the weight of several loaded symbols."

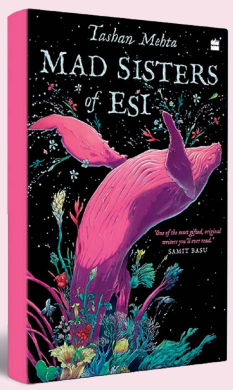
Lorenzo Searches... sees one of India's pre-eminent English-language writers in top form. Equal parts coming-of-age tale and theological riddle, this novel marks a new phase in Upamanyu Chatterjee's career. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha

Worlds Within Worlds

TASHAN MEHTA'S SECOND NOVEL, *MAD SISTERS OF ESI*, REVELS IN WORLD-BUILDING, THE CORNERSTONE OF GOOD FANTASY

This book is characterised by luminous prose and driven by a towering imagination. It features a very complicated, layered, fantastic universe with worlds and more worlds nested within yet more worlds. Two sisters wander within the body of a vast god whale, which is itself a universe. The whale swims in a black outer sea which is yet another universe.



MAD SISTERS OF ESI
by Tashan Mehta
HARPERCOLLINS
₹**599; 424** pages

Despite the **IMAGINATIVE** world-building, the book demands a lot from the reader

One of the sisters is content to continue to wander and explore the inner landscapes, while the other breaks out into an equally fantastic universe where there are shape-shifting islands and a strange, mad family that lives by (or rather abides by, since not all the characters involved are alive) apparently insane rules on one of those islands.

Where do they all come from and, indeed, where does the whale itself come from? That's it, that's the story, and it offers ample room for the author to play with multiple concepts, and to poke and prod and manoeuvre around the philosophical dimensions encompassing families, societal tribalism and the mutability of space and time.

From Tolkien to *The Witcher* to Westeros, world-building is one of the cornerstones of good fantasy. The fantasy universe can be as outré and weird as the writer likes, but it should have some dimensions of consistent internal logic and it should offer the writer free play to run to wherever those internal maps lead.

I can think of a couple of other fantastic universes that *Mad Sisters* reminded me of, although the world of the Whale and Esi are nothing like those spaces in their concrete details. One is Mervyn Peake's *Gormenghast* trilogy, where in the world of Titus Groan, there's an "outside" and there's Castle Gormenghast itself with its many layered complexities. This book evokes something of the same brooding complexity, and immanent sense of menace (apart from dealing with weird family dynamics). The other resonances came from the world of the graphic novel *The Unwritten* (by Mike Carey & Peter Gross) which also has that structure of nested dimensions and worlds within worlds.

However, despite the luminous prose, the imaginative world-building and the interesting denouements, the book demands a lot from the reader. The structure—the movement between characters and locations—is non-existent, or just slapped together without much thought.

This makes it very hard to understand where the characters are going, or what they are doing, or when. Certain things are not explained although they are critical to the storylines—they are just introduced as McGuffins. There is also extraneous material that could have been excised. In sum, the book could have been much more accessible if the editor had worked on it a little more.

Was it worth the effort to wade through the confusion? Indeed, but the first 50 pages were rather heavy going. Would I like to see another set of stories embedded in the same universe? Indeed, I would. In its own way, this is quite as good as *The Liar's Weave* (the author's first novel), but it is sculpted on a much larger scale and with far more ambition. ■

–Devangshu Datta